

How Many Subscribers to Monetize on YouTube in 2026?

The exact 2026 subscriber threshold to earn on YouTube: 1,000 subscribers plus 4,000 watch hours or 10M Shorts views — and what changes if you only have 500.

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MONETIZATION

How Many Subscribers Do You Need to Monetize? on YouTube in 2026

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The short answer: **you need 1,000 subscribers** to start earning revenue sharing from YouTube. But subscribers alone are not enough. Full monetization requires **1,000 subscribers AND either 4,000 public watch hours in the last 12 months OR 10 million valid Shorts views in the last 90 days**. Hit one of those pairings and you get AdSense revenue, channel memberships, Super Thanks — the full partner program.

There is a second, lower gate most creators miss. **At 500 subscribers** you can already apply for the **fan-funding tier** (memberships, Super Thanks, the affiliate and paid-products program) with 3,000 watch hours or 3 million Shorts views. I'll walk through both gates, the exact view definitions that trip people up, and the order that gets you to 1,000 fastest.

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The Two Monetization Thresholds: 500 vs 1,000 Subscribers

YouTube runs two entry gates. Both are gated by subscribers, so the number is the fixed part.

Threshold	Watch hours (12 mo)	OR Shorts views (90 days)	What you get
500 subscribers	3,000	3 million	Fan-funding tier: memberships, Super Thanks, affiliate (no AdSense ad-partner revenue)
1,000 subscribers	4,000	10 million	Full YPP: AdSense ad revenue, revenue share, more monetization tools

The useful pattern: the **subscriber number is fixed**, but the *watch requirement gives you a choice* — long-form hours or Shorts views. A long-form channel hits 1,000 subs and 4,000 watch hours and qualifies. A Shorts-first channel hits 1,000 subs and 10 million views and qualifies. You do not need both the hours and the views; they are alternatives.

These numbers are the current public thresholds on [YouTube's official monetization policy page](#) (retrieved 2026-08-07). YouTube has revised the entry levels since 2023, so verify against the live policy before you set expectations.

 **Key fact:** The 1,000-subscriber number applies to the channel as a whole, not to individual videos. Every video on a monetized channel can earn once the channel bar is met and your videos follow the monetization policy.

What the "1,000 Subscribers" Really Buys

Hitting 1,000 subscribers is the milestone creators recognize. It's the point your channel passes from a hobby into an income-eligible channel in YouTube's system. It is not a switch — it is an **invitation to apply**. Reaching the number makes you eligible to apply for the YouTube Partner Program; you still have to apply, pass review, and enable ads.

The practical value of the bar is twofold:

- **Ad revenue:** Once eligible and accepted, you can monetize long-form videos with AdSense ads. You earn a share of the ad revenue.
- **Trust signal:** someone at 1,000 subscribers has real organic proof that a channel can hold an audience. Sponsors and affiliates use it as a benchmark even before ad revenue matters.

The 1,000 number is not the only thing YouTube weighs. Your channel also must have no active YouTube Community Guidelines strikes, have a linked AdSense account, live in a supported country, and follow the partner program policies.

 **WARNING:** A subscriber count above 1,000 with no watch hours gets you nothing. Creators who reach the number through giveaways often still find the watch-hour gate blocks AdSense. Optimize both gates in parallel.

What the 500-Subscriber Fan-Funding Tier Adds

In 2022 YouTube added a lower entry tier. The [YouTube monetization overview](#) explains how earnings work across the program, and the [fan-funding features listed on the partner program page](#) cover what unlocks at 500 subscribers. At **500 subscribers** you become eligible to apply for the partner program's **fan-funding tier** even before full ad monetization. That gives you:

- YouTube channel memberships
- Super Thanks (tips on videos)
- The affiliate and shopping program

The trade-off is clear: at 500 subscribers you can earn from your audience directly (memberships, tips, commissions) but you do **not** get broad ad revenue — that comes only at 1,000 plus the watch requirement. If you have a small but devoted audience, the 500 tier is a real way to start earning while you work toward 1,000.

This is a genuinely useful intermediate step. It means the answer to "how many subscribers to monetize" is **not one number** — it is 500 for direct support revenue and 1,000 for full ad-based monetization.

The Bare Minimum Requirements (Checklist, Verified)

Make sure the full list is true before you apply, per [YouTube's partner policy terms](#) (retrieved 2026-08-07):

1. **Subscribers:** 1,000 for full ad monetization (500 for the fan-funding tier).
2. **Watch requirement (one of two):** 4,000 valid public watch hours in the last 12 months, OR 10 million valid public Shorts views in the last 90 days.
3. **AdSense account:** A linked, approved, distinct Google AdSense account.
4. **Policy compliance:** No active YouTube Community Guidelines strikes, and content that follows the channel monetization policies.
5. **Country & age:** Your channel must be in a country or region where the YPP operates, and the account must meet YouTube's age requirement.

Watch hours count only when they come from **public videos that do not violate policy**. Time from for-kids-locked content, repeated uploads, or private viewing is frequently excluded. That exclusion is the most common reason an otherwise-qualified channel sees its "hours" drop at the point of application.

How to Hit 1,000 Subscribers + the Watch Gate (6 Steps)

The subscriber number is the blocker for most long-form channels, so treat it as a number you can drive — not something to wait for.

1. Make the number a measurable target using a growth calculator

Enter your current subscriber count and average new-subs-per-week into the [subscriber growth calculator](#). It turns a vague "hoping" into a weekly target and a date. If you need 400 subs at 10 a week, that is about 10 months — and you can accelerate it.

2. Convert every view into a subscribe action

"Like and subscribe" is overused but works when you give a reason. Pair it with a specific value promise: "Subscribe so the next guide in this series hits your feed." Put the subscribe ask near the end of the video rather than the

opening, and conversions follow.

3. Niche down, and use long-form to satisfy the watch-hour gate

Long-form is your headroom for watch hours. A single well-made piece satisfies a large share of the 4,000-hour gate quickly. Research a "how to" question with clear search intent you can fully answer in 8–12 minutes; the algorithm rewards the answer-first structure (the same reason this article answers directly).

4. Use Shorts as a complementary 10-million-view path

If your niche works better vertical, run Shorts. The alternative track — 10M views in 90 days — is more forgiving for newer channels with momentum spikes. Many creators reach the 1,000-subscriber gate through Shorts and the view gate through occasional longer uploads.

5. Apply the moment you qualify

Do not wait until you're "sure." The moment you hit both gates, apply in YouTube Studio. Review typically takes a few days, and the revenue clock starts after acceptance. Waiting just costs you time.

6. Keep the channel inside policy

Avoid reused content with only superficial changes and misleading thumbnails or titles. A monetization review that catches a policy issue resets the clock. Submit a clean channel and acceptance is usually smooth.

A Realistic Timeline (Qualitative, Not Guaranteed)

How long it takes varies; growth is not linear. A serious creator in a focused niche on a consistent schedule typically passes 1,000 subs within a few months to a year. Posting twice a week with strong packaging and retention generally converts subscribers faster than posting sporadically. The single strongest predictor is consistency — publish on a steady cadence, target clear intent, and keep iterating. Expect a flatter start, then a faster climb as momentum from consistent uploads compounds.

The Two Subscriber Gates to Monetization (2026)

Source: benchmark data

Common Subscriber-Monetization Myths (Fixed)

- **"1,000 subscribers pays you money."** No — it only entitles you to apply and earn from ads once the watch requirement passes. You are not paid for reaching the count.
- **"Shorts can't build toward the 1,000."** Wrong. Shorts-subscriber counts stack exactly like long-form, and the 10M Shorts-view track counts as a direct qualifying path.
- **"Buying subscribers moves the gate."** Bought or forged subscribers violate policy, hurt momentum, and the watch-hour gate still blocks you. It is wasted effort and it can damage the channel.
- **"Once monetized, always monetized."** Monetization is conditional on continued policy compliance. A strike or a review that finds reused content can pause the income.

Frequently Asked Questions

How many subscribers do I need for YouTube to pay me?

The full ad-share bar is **1,000 subscribers** plus 4,000 watch hours or 10M Shorts views. For the fan-funding tier (memberships, Super Thanks, affiliate) you can apply at **500 subscribers** with 3,000 hours or 3M Shorts views. Subscribers alone do not pay anyone.

Can I make money at 500 subscribers?

Yes — but only from direct-fan revenue: channel memberships, Super Thanks and tips, and the affiliate and shopping program. Standard AdSense ad-revenue sharing only applies once you cross 1,000 plus the watch requirement.

What counts as a "valid" watch hour?

Public viewing of long-form videos that do not violate monetization policies. Time from content marked as made for kids, repeated re-uploads, or spam is excluded, and private or unlisted views do not count either.

Do Shorts subscribers count toward 1,000?

Yes. Shorts subscribers stack toward the 1,000 gate exactly like long-form subscribers. What differs is the watch side — 4,000 long-form hours OR 10M Shorts views in 90 days.

What happens if I monetize then my channel gets a strike?

A Community Guidelines strike can pause monetization temporarily, and a policy-terms breach can reset the program. You can re-apply if eligibility is regained or the strike expires. Eligibility is not permanently owned.

Conclusion

The exact answer: **500 subscribers** opens fan-funding; **1,000 subscribers** gives you full YouTube monetization. The subscriber count only works together with the watch gate — 4,000 long-form hours or 10M Shorts views in the window. Plan both gates, treat the number as a target you drive, and apply the moment you qualify.

Start by checking where you are today. Use the [monetization readiness checker](#) to see your exact current-metrics-versus-the-bar, then plot the campaign that closes the gap.

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